Wilhelm von Humboldt — Über die Kawi-Sprache auf der Insel Java (the Kawi-Werk proper) (1836–1839)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This edition is dedicated to Wilhelm von Humboldt, who died in 1835, before the three volumes of *Über die Kawi-Sprache auf der Insel Java* appeared through the Berlin Academy between 1836 and 1839. He never saw the finished form of the work his celebrated introduction was written to open. That introduction, a study of how human languages differ in their structure, became famous and is fully available in English in Peter Heath's translation, while the sustained study behind it — his study of the Kawi language of the island of Java — was never translated as a whole. The dedication honours the whole work, and not only its doorway.

The story

Many readers know one part of Wilhelm von Humboldt's last great work very well. Its introduction, *Über die Verschiedenheit des menschlichen Sprachbaues*, published in 1836 — a study of how human languages differ in their structure — is famous. In English it appears as *On Language*, in Peter Heath's complete translation, published by Cambridge University Press in 1999 and edited by Losonsky. That introduction is fully in English, and this dossier is explicit: do not re-translate it.

Behind that famous introduction stands the work it introduced, and that larger work is the subject here. *Über die Kawi-Sprache auf der Insel Java* — a study of the Kawi language of the island of Java — appeared in three volumes through the Berlin Academy between 1836 and 1839. The celebrated introduction occupies the roman-numeral front matter of the first volume. In other words, the part English readers know is the doorway. The three volumes behind the doorway were never translated as a whole.

Humboldt died in 1835, before the volumes appeared. The question this dossier set out to resolve was a narrow one, and resolving it changed the target: not whether Humboldt on language exists in English — in its most famous form, it does — but whether the Kawi work itself, the sustained study that the introduction was written to open, exists in English. On the evidence gathered here, it does not.

The work and what survives

Humboldt died in 1835, and the Kawi volumes of 1836–1839 are in the public domain.

A specialist history cited in the record states that there were no further editions of the work, and that the work has not been translated as a whole — only the introduction part has been translated into English.

The dossier also records a wider group of later linguistic projects, Humboldt's *Nachlass* — the material he left behind. Those projects were reconstructed in German only by the Berlin-Brandenburg Academy: the Basque work, in three volumes published between 2010 and 2022, and the Amerika-Werk, in six volumes published between 1994 and 2017. No English translations of any of these volumes were found after research.

A copyright caution belongs with that wider group. The modern Academy editions are in copyright as editions. A project of this kind translates from the 1836–39 print, or from manuscript, not from the Academy editions' apparatus — their editorial notes and scholarly framing.

Its English fortunes

The introduction is fully in English: Peter Heath's complete translation, *On Language*, Cambridge University Press, 1999, edited by Losonsky.

The Kawi work proper is in a different position. In the specialist history's words as carried in the record, the work has not been translated as a whole, and only the introduction part has been translated into English. No English translations of the Academy's Basque or Amerika-Werk volumes were found after research.

What completing it would take

Volume 1 of the Kawi work is the natural single unit. It gives the grammar of Old Javanese, or Kawi, together with Humboldt's argument about Sanskrit loanwords — words taken into the language from Sanskrit, the classical language of India.

This is specialist work. It requires German, Old Javanese, and Sanskrit, and the record describes the undertaking plainly as a larger effort than the Kanteletar or the López volume considered elsewhere in this collection. Nothing in that assessment changes the shape of the first step: one volume, taken whole, from the public-domain printing of 1836–1839.

Sources

- https://www.biblio.com/9780521660891 (Heath, *On Language*, CUP 1999 — the introduction covered)
- https://larouchepub.com/eiw/public/1998/eirv25n46-19981120/eirv25n46-19981120_030-wilhelm_von_humboldt_and_the_stu.pdf (flagged by the reviewer as corroboration of shape, not authority)
- https://scholarsbank.uoregon.edu/xmlui/bitstream/handle/1794/22968/Humboldt_languages_McNeely.pdf (specialist history; load-bearing source)
- https://refubium.fu-berlin.de/bitstream/handle/fub188/49796/hl.00183.tra.pdf (Academy Nachlass editions)